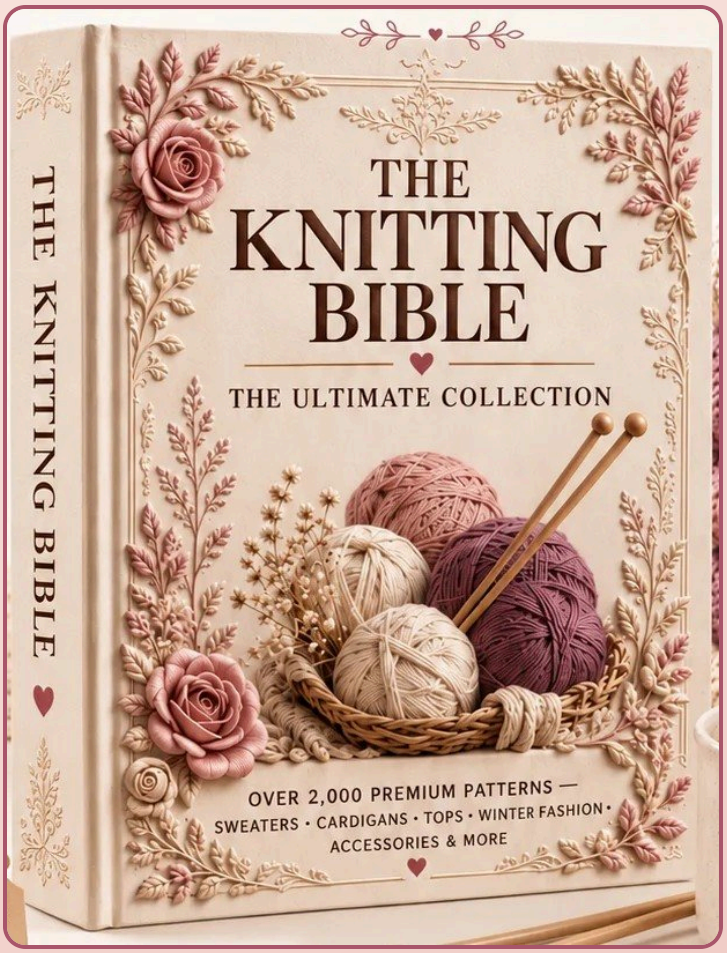
BONUS 1

Learn to Knit with 2 Needles

The step-by-step guide to your first knitted piece



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Welcome: Your First Knitted Piece Starts Here

> *Knitting is nothing more than one loop of yarn pulled through another loop, over and over. If you can hold two sticks and a piece of string, you can learn to knit, and this guide will take you from an empty needle to five finished projects.*

Everything in this guide is written for a true beginner. You do not need to know a single abbreviation, and you do not need any special talent. You need two needles, some yarn, a little patience, and about twenty minutes a day. Most people are making recognizable fabric within their first hour.

The guide moves in a deliberate order. First you will choose your tools and learn how to hold them. Then you will learn to cast on, make the two basic stitches, and bind off. After that come the skills that make knitting feel easy: reading your fabric, fixing mistakes, shaping with increases and decreases, and checking gauge. Finally you will put everything to work in five complete projects with exact numbers, a troubleshooting table, and a 14-day practice plan.

What you will make

- **A dishcloth** - 8 x 8 in (20 x 20 cm), your first real finished object.
- **A garter stitch scarf** - soft, squishy, and impossible to get wrong.
- **A ribbed headband** - your first stretchy fabric and your first seam.
- **A simple hat in the round** - circular needles, double-pointed needles, and crown decreases.
- **A basic baby blanket** - a larger project that builds stamina and rhythm.

> **How to use this guide**
>
> Read each chapter once, then keep the book open next to you while you knit. Do the exercises in order. If something does not click the first time, that is normal. Put it down, come back tomorrow, and try again; hands learn faster after a night of rest.

> **A word about safety**
>
> Needles can be sharp, so keep the tips pointed away from your face and from other people. Use blunt-tipped scissors or a small yarn snipper and cut with care. Small tools, stitch markers, and finished pieces with loose ends can be a choking hazard, so never leave them where small children or pets can reach them unsupervised.

Tools and Materials

A beginner kit is small and inexpensive. The trick is buying the right things first, not buying everything. A plain, smooth, medium-weight yarn and a pair of mid-size needles will teach you more than any fancy fiber ever could.

Yarn weights at a glance

Yarn is sorted into weights, from thread-thin lace to arm-thick jumbo. The weight tells you how thick the strand is and which needles it likes. The numbers below are typical ranges for stockinette stitch gauge over 4 inches (10 cm).

WEIGHT NAME	NUMBER	STS PER 4 IN (10 CM)	NEEDLE SIZE	GOOD FOR
Lace	0	33-40	US 000-1 (1.5-2.25 mm)	Shawls, doilies
Fingering / sock	1	27-32	US 1-3 (2.25-3.25 mm)	Socks, light shawls
Sport	2	23-26	US 3-5 (3.25-3.75 mm)	Baby items, light sweaters
DK / light	3	21-24	US 5-7 (3.75-4.5 mm)	Sweaters, baby wear
Worsted / medium	4	16-20	US 7-9 (4.5-5.5 mm)	Hats, blankets, dishcloths, learning
Bulky	5	12-15	US 9-11 (5.5-8 mm)	Scarves, quick hats
Super bulky	6	7-11	US 11 and up (8 mm+)	Chunky blankets, cowls
Jumbo	7	6 or fewer	US 17 and up (12.75 mm+)	Arm knitting, rugs

Needle sizes

Needles are sold by US size number and by millimeter diameter. The two systems do not line up in a neat pattern, so keep this table handy. The bigger the number, the thicker the needle and the looser the fabric.

US SIZE	METRIC (MM)	TYPICAL USE
0	2.0	Fine socks, lace
1	2.25	Socks
2	2.75	Socks, baby items
3	3.25	Fine garments
4	3.5	Light garments
5	3.75	Sport weight
6	4.0	Ribbing, DK
7	4.5	Cotton dishcloths, DK/worsted
8	5.0	Worsted hats and headbands
9	5.5	Worsted blankets

US SIZE	METRIC (MM)	TYPICAL USE
10	6.0	Bulky
10.5	6.5	Bulky scarves
11	8.0	Super bulky
13	9.0	Super bulky
15	10.0	Jumbo
17	12.75	Jumbo

Needle materials and types

- **Bamboo and wood** have a little grip, so stitches do not slide off by accident. They are the friendliest choice for a first pair.
- **Metal** needles are slick and fast, which experienced knitters love and beginners sometimes find slippery.
- **Plastic** needles are light and inexpensive, though they can flex in larger sizes.
- **Straight needles** have a point on one end and a stopper on the other. They suit scarves and dishcloths.
- **Circular needles** are two points joined by a flexible cable. They knit flat pieces and tubes, and they hold large projects in your lap instead of on your arms.
- **Double-pointed needles (DPN)** come in sets of four or five and are used for small tubes such as the top of a hat.

The small tools

- Blunt tapestry needle (for weaving in ends and seaming)
- Sharp scissors or a snipper
- Measuring tape or a flexible ruler
- Stitch markers (removable ones are the most useful) and a few safety pins
- A crochet hook, size H-8 (5 mm) or smaller, for rescuing dropped stitches
- A notebook for gauge numbers and row counts

What to buy first

1. **One pair of straight needles, US 8 (5 mm), bamboo or wood.**
2. **Two skeins of smooth, light-colored worsted weight yarn**, preferably a plain wool blend or acrylic. Light colors show your stitches clearly; avoid fuzzy, dark, or sparkly yarn for now.
3. **One skein of worsted weight cotton** for the dishcloth.
4. **A tapestry needle and scissors.**

Wait on the rest

Buy the circular needle, the double-pointed needles, and the bulky yarn only when you reach the project that needs them. Your first few weeks are about hands and habits, not gear.

How to Hold the Needles and Yarn

There is no single correct way to hold your needles. What matters is that your hands are relaxed and your yarn has gentle, even tension. Two grips dominate: continental (yarn in the left hand) and English (yarn in the right hand). Try both for a few minutes each, then pick the one that feels more natural. You can always switch later.

Holding the needles

Hold each needle loosely, like a pencil or like a fork, whichever feels comfortable. Rest the ends of the needles lightly against your body or in your lap so they do not stab the air. Your grip should never be white-knuckled. If your hands ache, you are holding too tightly.

English method (yarn in the right hand)

1. Hold the needle with the stitches in your left hand and the empty needle in your right.
2. Lay the working yarn over the first finger of your right hand, and loop it once around your pinky or ring finger to create tension.
3. Use your right forefinger to wrap the yarn around the needle tip.

This method is easy to learn because it looks like the diagrams in most books, and it is a good choice if you already crochet with your right hand.

Continental method (yarn in the left hand)

1. Hold the needle with the stitches in your right hand this time, and the empty needle in your left, so that the stitched needle crosses to the left hand when working.
2. Wrap the yarn over your left forefinger and around your pinky for tension.
3. Use the tip of the right needle to pick the yarn off your left forefinger.

Continental knitters make smaller movements and usually knit faster once it becomes second nature. It is also slightly kinder to purl because the yarn is already in place.

Tension is trained, not born

If the yarn feels too tight, loosen the wrap around your pinky. If stitches flop around, add one extra wrap. Aim for stitches that slide on the needle without sagging. Expect uneven stitches in your first few inches; that is part of learning, not a mistake.

The Slip Knot: Where Every Piece Begins

Almost every cast-on starts with a slip knot, which is simply an adjustable loop that sits on your needle and counts as your first stitch.

1. Leave a tail of about 6 inches (15 cm). Make a loop by crossing the yarn tail over the working yarn.
2. Reach through the loop with your finger or a needle tip and pull up a loop of the working yarn.
3. Slide the new loop onto the needle and pull both strands to snug it up.
4. Tug the working yarn (not the tail) to tighten it so the loop is snug but not strangled around the needle.

> **Check your knot**
>
> A correct slip knot slides easily along the working yarn when you pull the tail, and it tightens when you pull the working yarn. If it does the opposite, undo it and make it again.

Three Ways to Cast On

Casting on creates the first row of stitches. There are dozens of methods, but three will carry you through almost every beginner pattern. Each one gives a slightly different edge, so it helps to know all three.

CAST-ON	NEEDS A TAIL?	EDGE	BEST FOR
Long-tail	Yes	Neat, firm, stretchy	Most projects, hats, scarves
Knitted	No	Soft, a bit loose	Learning, adding stitches mid-row
Cable	No	Firm, rope-like	Edges that must hold shape, blanket borders

Long-tail cast-on

This is the classic. It needs a tail, and the trick is guessing the length. Use roughly 1 inch (2.5 cm) of tail per stitch plus 6 inches (15 cm) extra. For 21 stitches, that is about 27 inches (69 cm), or three-quarters of a yard.

1. Make a slip knot, leaving your measured tail, and put it on the right needle.
2. Hold the needle in your right hand. With your left hand, spread the tail strand over your thumb and the working strand over your forefinger, making a V (slingshot position).
3. Bring the needle tip up through the loop on your thumb from underneath.
4. Swing the needle over the strand on your forefinger and catch it.
5. Pull that strand back down through the thumb loop.
6. Slip your thumb out and use it to pull the tail gently to snug the new stitch on the needle.
7. Repeat steps 3 to 6 until you have the number of stitches the pattern asks for. Remember that the slip knot counts as stitch one.

Knitted cast-on

This method needs no tail, so you can never run out of yarn. It builds stitches by knitting into the previous one.

1. Make a slip knot and put it on the left needle.
2. Insert the right needle into the loop from front to back, as if you were going to knit.
3. Wrap the yarn around the right needle and pull up a loop.
4. Instead of dropping the old stitch, slip the new loop onto the left needle by inserting the left needle tip into it from right to left.
5. Tighten gently and repeat from step 2 until you have all your stitches.

Cable cast-on

The cable cast-on is almost the same, except you insert the needle between the last two stitches instead of into the last stitch. That makes a firmer, ropier edge.

1. Cast on two stitches with the knitted cast-on.
2. Insert the right needle between the first two stitches on the left needle, from front to back.
3. Wrap the yarn, pull up a loop, and place it onto the left needle.
4. Repeat step 2 between the first two stitches each time until you have the required number.

> **Cast on loosely**
> A tight cast-on is the number one beginner trap. If your edge pulls in, cast on over two needles held together, then slide one out before knitting the first row. The edge will have more stretch.

> **Count as you go**
> After casting on, count your stitches. Counting the slip knot as stitch one, tick off every ten with a stitch marker or a scrap of contrasting yarn. A miscount now becomes a wonky edge later.

The Knit Stitch

The knit stitch is the foundation of everything. Knit every row and you make garter stitch; mix it with purl and you make every other texture you will see in this guide. Practice on a cast-on of 20 stitches and knit until you are bored. Boredom means muscle memory is building.

Step by step (English method)

1. Hold the needle with the stitches in your left hand. Keep the working yarn at the back of the work.
2. Insert the right needle tip into the first stitch from front to back (left to right), passing underneath the left needle.
3. Wrap the working yarn counterclockwise around the right needle tip, from back to front.
4. Pull the right needle toward you through the stitch, bringing the new loop with it.
5. Slide the old stitch off the left needle. You now have one new stitch on the right needle.
6. Repeat across the row. When all stitches are on the right needle, switch the needles and start the next row.

For continental knitters, the same motions apply, but you scoop the yarn with the right needle tip instead of wrapping it with your hand.

Common beginner problems

- **Stitches too tight to move.** Relax your grip and wrap the yarn more loosely.
- **Splitting the yarn.** Insert the needle tip into the center of the stitch, and slow down.
- **Extra stitches appearing.** You may be wrapping the yarn twice or knitting into the bar between stitches. Count at the end of every row.
- **Fewer stitches than you started with.** You probably skipped a stitch, or knitted two together without meaning to.

> **Practice goal**
>
> Knit 10 rows of 20 stitches each. When your last row looks neater than your first, you are ready to move on.

The Purl Stitch

The purl stitch is the knit stitch's mirror image. The yarn lives at the front of the work, and the needle goes in from back to front. Do not worry if it feels clumsy at first; almost everyone finds the purl awkward for a day or two.

1. Hold the needle with the stitches in your left hand and bring the working yarn to the front of the work, between the two needles.
2. Insert the right needle tip into the first stitch from back to front (right to left), in front of the left needle.
3. Wrap the yarn counterclockwise around the right needle tip, bringing it from the back over the top and down to the front.
4. Push the right needle tip back and away from you through the stitch, bringing the new loop with it.
5. Slide the old stitch off the left needle.
6. Repeat across the row.

> **Moving the yarn**
>
> To go from knit to purl in the same row, bring the yarn forward between the needles. To go from purl to knit, take it back. Always move the yarn between the tips of the needles, never over the top, or you will create an accidental extra stitch (a yarn over).

Try this exercise: cast on 20 stitches, then knit one row and purl one row, alternating. After 10 rows you will see a smooth fabric on one side and a bumpy one on the other. That is stockinette stitch, and you have just made your first real fabric.

Stockinette, Garter, Rib, and Seed

Almost every beginner pattern uses one of four basic fabrics. They are all built from knit and purl stitches in different arrangements.

FABRIC	HOW TO MAKE IT (FLAT)	LOOK AND FEEL	CURLS?
Garter	Knit every row	Bumpy ridges, thick, stretchy	No, lies flat
Stockinette	Knit RS rows, purl WS rows	Smooth V-shapes on the front, bumpy back	Yes, curls at the edges
Rib (k2, p2)	Repeat k2, p2 across every row	Stretchy columns, snug	No, pulls in
Seed	Alternate k1, p1; on the next row knit the purls and purl the knits	Pebbly texture, flat	No, lies flat

Garter stitch

Knit every row. Every second row forms one ridge, so counting ridges is half the effort of counting rows. Garter is dense, warm, and forgiving, which is why it is the best fabric for your first scarf.

Stockinette stitch

Knit on the right side (RS), purl on the wrong side (WS). In the round, you knit every round and get stockinette without ever purling. Flat stockinette curls toward the back at the top and bottom and toward the front at the sides, so it usually gets a border of garter, seed, or rib.

Ribbing

Ribbing alternates columns of knit and purl stitches. The most common versions are k1, p1 rib and k2, p2 rib. Ribbing pulls the fabric together and stretches back, so it is perfect for hat brims, cuffs, and headbands. Always work the stitches as they face you: knit the knits, purl the purls.

- For k2, p2 rib worked flat, cast on a multiple of 4 stitches plus 2.
- Row 1 (RS): k2, *p2, k2; repeat from * to end.
- Row 2 (WS): p2, *k2, p2; repeat from * to end.

Seed stitch

On an odd number of stitches: every row is k1, p1, repeated, ending with k1. Seed stitch has no wrong or right side to worry about and lies perfectly flat, so it makes an ideal border.

Reading Your Knitting and Counting Rows

Once you can see what your stitches are doing, you can fix problems before they grow. The three skills below will make you much more confident.

Telling knit from purl

- A knit stitch looks like a small V, stacked like tiny braids.
- A purl stitch looks like a small bump or a horizontal dash.
- On stockinette, the knit side shows columns of Vs. The purl side shows rows of bumps.

Counting rows

- **Stockinette:** count the Vs in a single column from bottom to top. Each V is one row.
- **Garter:** count the ridges (the raised bumps on one side). Each ridge equals two rows, so multiply by 2.
- **Rib and seed:** pick a knit column and count the stitches in it, the same way as stockinette.

Counting stitches

Count the loops on the needle, not the bumps below it. Place a marker or a piece of scrap yarn after every ten stitches so you only count ten at a time. Write the count in your notebook, along with the row number.

Right side and wrong side

The right side (RS) is the side that will show when the piece is finished; the wrong side (WS) is the side that will hide. In garter stitch both sides look the same, so tie a scrap of yarn to the cast-on corner on the RS to keep track.

> **Row counter trick**
>
> A small tally mark in your notebook after each row works just as well as a counter. Make it a habit before you put the work down: write the row number you just finished.

Binding Off

Binding off (also called casting off) closes your stitches so the fabric does not unravel. The basic method is simple and works for everything in this guide.

1. Knit the first two stitches of the row.
2. Insert the left needle tip into the first stitch you knitted (the one farther from the tip) and lift it over the second stitch and off the right needle. One stitch has been bound off.
3. Knit the next stitch. Again lift the earlier stitch over the new one.
4. Repeat until one stitch remains on the right needle.
5. Cut the yarn, leaving a tail of at least 6 inches (15 cm). For seaming, leave about 3 times the seam length.
6. Pull the tail through the last loop and tighten it.

> **Bind off loosely**
>
> A tight bind-off is the twin of a tight cast-on. Use a needle one or two sizes larger in your right hand for the bind-off row, or keep your stitches loose by wrapping the yarn less tightly. In rib, bind off in pattern: knit the knits and purl the purls.

Changing Yarn and Weaving in Ends

Joining a new ball

Always join new yarn at the edge of your work, at the start of a row, if you can. This keeps the join where the seam or border will hide it.

1. Finish your row with the old yarn, leaving a tail of at least 6 inches (15 cm).
2. Drop the old yarn. Take the new yarn and begin the next row, leaving a tail of at least 6 inches (15 cm).
3. Knit the first two stitches with the new yarn held snug. You can tie a loose knot at this point and undo it later when you weave in the ends.

In a project of a single color, you can also join mid-row by laying the two tails side by side for two or three stitches. This is stronger but can leave a thick spot.

Weaving in ends

1. Thread the tail onto a tapestry needle.
2. On the wrong side, run the needle under the horizontal bars of about 6 to 8 stitches in one direction.
3. Turn and run the needle back through about 3 stitches in the other direction to lock it in.
4. Tug the fabric gently sideways to even the stitches, then snip the tail close to the fabric.

> **Never knot permanently**
>
> Knots can pop through the fabric and leave a hole after washing. Weave in every tail instead.

Fixing Mistakes

Every knitter makes mistakes, and every knitter learns to fix them. The fix is rarely as scary as it looks. Take a breath, find the problem, and then choose the smallest repair.

Dropped stitch

1. Stop knitting. Do not pull on the yarn.
2. Put a safety pin or stitch marker through the dropped stitch so it cannot run further.
3. If the stitch has run down several rows, use a crochet hook. Insert the hook into the loop from front to back, then catch the horizontal bar above it from the back and pull it through the loop.
4. Repeat for each bar until you reach the top row, then place the stitch back on the left needle, making sure it is not twisted.

Twisted stitch

A stitch that sits the wrong way on the needle looks tight and crossed. In most cases it simply needs to be mounted the right way: the leading edge of the loop (the strand closest to the tip) should be at the front. If

you have a twisted stitch in the row below, knit it through the back loop to correct it as you go, or take it off and put it back on facing the right direction.

Unraveling (ripping back)

1. Place the work on a table. Pull the needle out of all the stitches gently.
2. Gently tug the yarn to unravel to the row before the mistake. You can go one row at a time or several at once.
3. Pick up the stitches with a needle one size smaller to make it easier, making sure all the stitches are mounted the same way.
4. Count to be sure the stitch count matches, then continue knitting.

Lifelines

A lifeline is a thread run through a row of stitches as insurance. If you have to rip back, you stop at the lifeline and the stitches are already held for you.

1. Thread a tapestry needle with a smooth, contrasting cotton thread or dental floss.
2. Run it through each stitch on the needle, following the line of stitches across the row (be careful not to catch the yarn that is between stitches).
3. Leave the ends hanging out of the sides and keep knitting. Later, if you rip back, stop at the lifeline.

Tinking (knitting backwards)

Tink is the word knit spelled backwards. It lets you undo one stitch at a time without removing the needles. Use it for fixing a mistake within the last few stitches.

1. With the yarn at the back, insert the left needle tip into the stitch below the first stitch on the right needle, from front to back.
2. Slip the stitch off the right needle by pulling the right needle gently out.
3. Gently pull the working yarn to undo the stitch, then slide the original stitch back on the left needle.
4. Repeat for each stitch that needs undoing.

> **Forgiveness rule**
>
> If a mistake is tiny and hidden in the middle of a scarf, leave it. Real, handmade fabric has character. Fix mistakes that change the stitch count or the shape, and let the rest go.

Increases and Decreases

Increases add stitches and decreases remove them. Together they shape your knitting: wider, narrower, curved, or pointed. You will use them in the hat crown, but they appear in nearly every pattern you will ever read.

ABBREVIATION	NAME	EFFECT	WHEN TO USE
kfb	Knit into front and back	+1 st, leaves a small bump	Quick, simple increase at the edge
M1	Make one	+1 st, nearly invisible	Increasing inside the fabric
k2tog	Knit two together	-1 st, leans right	Most decreases, crowns
ssk	Slip, slip, knit	-1 st, leans left	Paired with k2tog for symmetry

Kfb: knit into the front and back

1. Knit into the front of the stitch as usual, but do not slide the old stitch off the left needle.
2. Move the right needle behind the left needle and knit into the back loop of the same stitch.
3. Slide the old stitch off. You now have two stitches from one.

M1: make one

1. Use the left needle tip to lift the horizontal strand between the stitch you just knitted and the next stitch, from front to back.
2. Knit into the back of this lifted loop to twist it and close the hole.

K2tog: knit two together

Insert the right needle into the next two stitches at the same time, from left to right, as if to knit, and knit them as one stitch. The result leans to the right.

Ssk: slip, slip, knit

1. Slip the first stitch knitwise onto the right needle, then slip the second stitch knitwise as well.
2. Insert the left needle into the front of both stitches (from left to right) and knit them together through the back loops.

The result leans to the left. Using k2tog on one side and ssk on the other makes a mirror image, which is what a good shape needs.

> **Which one for the hat?**
>
> The crown of the hat in this guide uses only k2tog, which is the easiest decrease. Later you can switch to a mix of ssk and k2tog for a symmetrical look.

Swatching and Gauge

Gauge is the number of stitches and rows that fit into 4 inches (10 cm) of fabric. It controls the final size of your project. A hat knitted at 4.5 stitches per inch is an inch bigger around than the same hat at 5 stitches per inch, so matching gauge is the difference between a gift that fits and one that does not.

How to knit a swatch

1. Cast on 8 stitches more than the pattern's 4-inch (10 cm) gauge number. For 18 stitches per 4 inches, cast on 26.
2. Knit the stitch the pattern uses until the piece is at least 5 inches (13 cm) tall.
3. Bind off loosely and wash and dry the swatch the way you will care for the finished piece.
4. Lay it flat and place a ruler across the middle of the swatch. Count the stitches within 4 inches (10 cm), then count the rows within 4 inches (10 cm). Measure in the center, not at the edges.

What to do with the numbers

- **More stitches than the pattern:** your knitting is tighter. Try a needle one size larger.
- **Fewer stitches than the pattern:** your knitting is looser. Try a needle one size smaller.
- **Rows off but stitches right:** match the stitches; the length can be adjusted by working more or fewer rows.

> **Quick check**
>
> Example: if the pattern says 18 stitches over 4 inches and you get 20, divide 20 by 4 to get 5 stitches per inch. A hat that should measure 19 inches would then be only 17 inches around if you cast on the pattern's stitch count. Change needles and swatch again.

Reading a Pattern

A pattern is a recipe. It tells you what you need, the gauge, the sizes, and the instructions in a shorthand to save space. Read the entire pattern before starting, and highlight any parts you do not understand.

Common abbreviations

ABBREVIATION	MEANING
k	knit
p	purl
st(s)	stitch(es)
RS / WS	right side / wrong side
CO	cast on
BO	bind off
k2tog	knit 2 stitches together
ssk	slip, slip, knit
kfb	knit into front and back of stitch

ABBREVIATION	MEANING
M1	make one stitch
yo	yarn over
pm	place marker
sm	slip marker
rnd	round
rep	repeat
beg	beginning
dec	decrease
inc	increase
sl	slip
DPN	double-pointed needle(s)

Asterisks and brackets

- **Asterisks (*)** mark the start of a section to be repeated. In the line *k2, *p2, k2; repeat from * to end*, you work the part after the asterisk again and again until the row ends.
- **Brackets [ ] and parentheses ( )** group steps that are repeated a specific number of times. *[K2, p2] 3 times* means k2, p2, k2, p2, k2, p2.
- **Numbers after a letter** mean how many stitches: k3 means knit three stitches.
- **"Work even"** means to continue in the established pattern without increases or decreases.

> **Worked example**
>
> Row: k2, *p2, k2; repeat from * to end. On a 22-stitch row, you knit the first 2, then repeat (p2, k2) five times: 2 + 5 x 4 = 22 stitches, ending exactly on a knit pair. If your count does not land there, check how many you cast on.

Finishing: Weaving, Blocking, and Seaming

Finishing takes a piece from looking homemade to looking handmade. Plan 20 minutes for it even on small projects.

Weave in the ends

Use the technique from the earlier chapter. For garter, weave along the ridge. For stockinette, follow a column of stitches along the wrong side. Leave the end alone until after blocking so it can relax.

Blocking

Blocking gently sets the stitches by wetting the fabric and letting it dry in shape. It evens out uneven stitches, flattens curling edges, and opens up the fabric.

1. Check the yarn label. Wool and most blends can be soaked in cool water with a splash of mild soap. Acrylic should be steamed lightly rather than soaked; hold the iron or steamer above the fabric without touching it.
2. Soak for 15 minutes, then press (do not wring) the water out in a clean towel.
3. Lay the piece on a dry towel or foam mat, smooth it to the measurements in the pattern, and pin it if it needs sharp corners.
4. Leave it flat until fully dry, which can take a day.

> **Cotton and acrylic**
>
> Cotton can be blocked wet like wool. Do not press a hot iron on acrylic or you can melt and flatten the fibers permanently.

Seaming with mattress stitch

Mattress stitch joins two edges invisibly. Use it for the headband in this guide, and for any seam on a flat piece.

1. Lay the two edges side by side, right sides up, with the cast-on edges at the bottom.
2. Thread a tapestry needle with a tail about 3 times the seam length.
3. Find the bar between the first and second stitches at the bottom of the right piece. Slide the needle under 2 bars, then do the same on the left piece, directly across.
4. Zigzag back and forth, going under 2 bars each side, for about an inch (2.5 cm).
5. Gently pull the thread snug. The seam disappears as the edges draw together.
6. Continue to the top, pulling after every inch, then weave in the end.

Five Beginner Projects

Each project below gives the exact materials, gauge, stitch counts, and steps. All numbers have been checked against the gauge listed. Knit the swatch first, adjust your needle size if needed, and keep your notebook open.

Project 1: Garter Stitch Dishcloth (8 x 8 in / 20 x 20 cm)

A small, fast, useful piece that teaches cast-on, garter stitch, and bind-off. Cotton is firm and absorbent, so it wipes counters beautifully and holds up to hot washes.

- **Yarn:** about 85 yards (78 m) of worsted weight cotton (one 1.75 oz / 50 g ball)
- **Needles:** US 7 (4.5 mm) straight needles
- **Tools:** tapestry needle, scissors
- **Gauge:** 20 stitches and 40 rows (20 ridges) = 4 in (10 cm) in garter stitch
- **Finished size:** 8 x 8 in (20 x 20 cm)

The math: 8 in / 4 in = 2 repeats of the gauge. 20 stitches x 2 = 40 stitches. 40 rows x 2 = 80 rows, which is 40 ridges.

1. Cast on 40 stitches using the long-tail method (tail about 46 inches, or 1 inch per stitch plus 6 inches).
2. Row 1: knit all 40 stitches.
3. Repeat the knit row until you have 80 rows in total, or 40 ridges on one side. Count carefully.
4. Bind off loosely, knitting each stitch.
5. Weave in both ends and steam lightly or wash and dry the dishcloth.

DISHCLOTH CHECKLIST

☐ Swatch matches 20 stitches per 4 in

☐ Cast on 40 stitches and counted them

☐ Knit 80 rows (40 ridges)

☐ Bound off loosely

☐ Ends woven in

☐ Measures about 8 x 8 in (20 x 20 cm)

> **Make it your own**
>
> Add a stripe by switching to a second color every 10 ridges. Four ridges at the start and end in a contrast color make a neat border.

Project 2: Garter Stitch Scarf (6 x 60 in / 15 x 152 cm)

Garter stitch lies flat and looks the same on both sides, so this scarf needs no purling and no shaping. It is the project most people knit first.

- **Yarn:** about 250 yards (230 m) of bulky weight yarn (two skeins of about 125 yards)
- **Needles:** US 10.5 (6.5 mm) straight needles
- **Tools:** tapestry needle, scissors
- **Gauge:** 14 stitches and 28 rows (14 ridges) = 4 in (10 cm) in garter stitch
- **Finished size:** 6 in wide x 60 in long (15 x 152 cm)

The math: 14 stitches / 4 in = 3.5 stitches per inch. 6 in x 3.5 = 21 stitches. 28 rows / 4 in = 7 rows per inch. 60 in x 7 = 420 rows, which is 210 ridges.

1. Cast on 21 stitches (long-tail needs about 27 inches of tail).
2. Knit every row.
3. Continue until the scarf is 60 inches long, about 420 rows. Measure it unstretched and hanging from the needles.
4. When you start a new ball, join it at the start of a row.
5. Bind off loosely and weave in the ends.

6. Steam or block lightly to even out the stitches.

SCARF CHECKLIST

☐ Swatch matches 14 stitches per 4 in

☐ Cast on 21 stitches

☐ Joined new yarn at the edge

☐ Reached 60 in, about 420 rows

☐ Bound off loosely

☐ Ends woven in

Project 3: Ribbed Headband (4 x 18 in / 10 x 46 cm)

A headband knits sideways as a long rectangle and joins into a loop. It introduces rib, a stretchy fabric, and your first seam.

- **Yarn:** about 70 yards (64 m) of worsted weight wool or wool blend
- **Needles:** US 8 (5 mm) straight needles
- **Tools:** tapestry needle, scissors, measuring tape
- **Gauge:** 22 stitches and 28 rows = 4 in (10 cm) in k2, p2 rib, relaxed (not stretched)
- **Finished size:** 4 in tall x 18 in around (10 x 46 cm), stretches to fit heads of 21 to 23 in (53 to 58 cm)

The math: 4 in tall x 5.5 stitches per inch = 22 stitches. k2, p2 rib flat needs a multiple of 4 plus 2: 4 x 5 + 2 = 22. For length, 28 rows / 4 in = 7 rows per inch, so 18 in x 7 = 126 rows. The headband is about 3 to 5 in smaller than the head so it stays on.

1. Cast on 22 stitches.
2. Row 1 (RS): k2, *p2, k2; repeat from * to end. You should work 5 repeats.
3. Row 2 (WS): p2, *k2, p2; repeat from * to end.
4. Repeat Rows 1 and 2 until you have worked 126 rows (63 repeats of the two-row pair). The piece should measure about 18 in, relaxed.
5. Bind off in pattern (knit the knits, purl the purls), leaving a 40-inch tail for seaming.
6. Use mattress stitch to join the two short ends, working one stitch in from the edge. Weave in the ends.

HEADBAND CHECKLIST

- ☐ Swatch matches 22 stitches per 4 in in rib
- ☐ Cast on 22 stitches (multiple of 4 plus 2)
- ☐ Worked 126 rows
- ☐ Bound off in pattern
- ☐ Seam joined with mattress stitch
- ☐ Fits snugly over the ears

> **Fit tip**
> Wrap the knitted strip around the head before seaming. If it overlaps comfortably with 1 inch to spare, it is ready. Add or remove 7 rows per inch to resize.

Project 4: Simple Hat in the Round (adult medium, 19 in / 48 cm)

Your first project in the round uses no purling except in the rib, and teaches you to switch from a circular needle to double-pointed needles as the crown closes.

- **Yarn:** about 150 yards (137 m) of worsted weight yarn; buy 200 yards (183 m) to be safe
- **Needles:** US 6 (4 mm) 16-inch circular needle for the brim; US 8 (5 mm) 16-inch circular needle for the body; US 8 (5 mm) set of 4 or 5 DPN for the crown
- **Tools:** 1 removable stitch marker for the start of the round, 8 optional stitch markers for the crown, tapestry needle, scissors
- **Gauge:** 18 stitches and 24 rounds = 4 in (10 cm) in stockinette on US 8 (5 mm)
- **Finished size:** 19 in (48 cm) circumference, about 9 in (23 cm) tall; fits head sizes 21 to 22 in (53 to 56 cm)

The math: 18 stitches / 4 in = 4.5 stitches per inch. 19 in x 4.5 = 85.5, rounded up to 88 stitches, which is a multiple of 4 for the rib (88 / 4 = 22 repeats) and of 8 for the crown (88 / 8 = 11 stitches per wedge).

Brim and body

1. With the US 6 (4 mm) circular needle, cast on 88 stitches using the long-tail method (tail about 94 inches, or 1 inch per stitch plus 6 inches). Check that the stitches are not twisted around the cable.
2. Place the marker and join to work in the round by knitting the first stitch cast on.
3. Rounds 1 to 12: *k2, p2; repeat from * to end of round. This is 22 repeats of k2, p2.
4. Switch to the US 8 (5 mm) circular needle. Knit every round until the piece measures 6 in (15 cm) from the cast-on edge, about 25 rounds.

Crown decreases

There are 8 wedges of 11 stitches each. Place a marker after every 11 stitches on the first decrease round so you can see the wedges. Switch to DPN when the stitches no longer fit comfortably on the circular needle (after round 9).

ROUND	INSTRUCTION	STITCHES LEFT
1	*K9, k2tog; repeat from * 8 times	80
2	Knit	80
3	*K8, k2tog; repeat 8 times	72
4	Knit	72
5	*K7, k2tog; repeat 8 times	64
6	Knit	64
7	*K6, k2tog; repeat 8 times	56
8	Knit	56
9	*K5, k2tog; repeat 8 times	48
10	Knit	48
11	*K4, k2tog; repeat 8 times	40
12	Knit	40
13	*K3, k2tog; repeat 8 times	32
14	Knit	32
15	*K2, k2tog; repeat 8 times	24
16	Knit	24
17	*K1, k2tog; repeat 8 times	16
18	*K2tog; repeat 8 times	8

Each decrease round removes 8 stitches: 88 - 8 = 80, then 72, 64, 56, 48, 40, 32, 24, 16, and finally 8. The crown is 18 rounds, or about 3 in (7.5 cm) at 6 rounds per inch, so the total height is 6 + 3 = 9 inches.

Closing the top

1. Cut the yarn, leaving a 10-inch (25 cm) tail.
2. Thread the tail onto a tapestry needle and run it through the remaining 8 stitches, slipping each one off the needle as you go.
3. Pull tight, push the tail through to the wrong side, and weave it in securely.
4. Weave in the cast-on tail, then block the hat over a bowl or plate to shape the top.

HAT CHECKLIST

☐ Swatch in the round matches 18 stitches per 4 in

☐ Cast on 88 stitches, not twisted

☐ Worked 12 rounds of k2, p2 rib

☐ Body measures 6 in from the cast-on edge

☐ Crown decreases from 88 to 8 stitches

☐ Top closed and ends woven in

☐ Blocked over a bowl

Magic loop or DPN

If you prefer, use a long circular needle (32 inches or more) and the magic loop method instead of DPN. Either way, the stitch counts do not change.

Fit and safety

If the hat is for a baby or child, sew down any loose ends securely and skip decorations such as buttons or pom-poms attached with thread; these can come loose and become choking hazards.

Project 5: Basic Baby Blanket (30 x 36 in / 76 x 91 cm)

A larger project that builds rhythm. Seed stitch borders keep the stockinette center from curling, so the blanket lies flat without any blocking tricks.

- **Yarn:** about 880 yards (805 m) of washable worsted weight yarn; buy 1,000 yards (915 m) to be safe
- **Needles:** US 9 (5.5 mm) circular needle, 32 inches (80 cm) or longer, used flat
- **Tools:** tapestry needle, scissors, measuring tape
- **Gauge:** 18 stitches and 26 rows = 4 in (10 cm) in stockinette on US 9 (5.5 mm)
- **Finished size:** 30 x 36 in (76 x 91 cm)

The math: 18 stitches / 4 in = 4.5 stitches per inch. 30 in x 4.5 = 135 stitches. That is 5 border stitches + 125 center stitches + 5 border stitches = 135. For length, 26 rows / 4 in = 6.5 rows per inch. 36 in x 6.5 = 234 rows. That is 7 border rows + 220 center rows + 7 border rows = 234.

1. Cast on 135 stitches using the cable cast-on (no tail needed).
2. Rows 1 to 7: *k1, p1; repeat from * to the last stitch, k1. Every row is the same because 135 is an odd number.
3. Row 8 (WS) and every WS row: k1, p1, k1, p1, k1 (seed border), purl 125, then k1, p1, k1, p1, k1.
4. Row 9 (RS) and every RS row: k1, p1, k1, p1, k1 (seed border), knit 125, then k1, p1, k1, p1, k1.
5. Continue this way through row 227. That is 220 rows of border and stockinette center (rows 8 to 227). Measure; the blanket should be about 35 in tall.
6. Rows 228 to 234: repeat the seed stitch row from rows 1 to 7 across all 135 stitches.
7. Bind off loosely in pattern. Weave in the ends and wash according to the yarn label.

BLANKET CHECKLIST

☐ Swatch matches 18 stitches per 4 in and 26 rows per 4 in

☐ Cast on 135 stitches

☐ Seed border: 7 rows at the bottom

☐ Center: 220 rows with 5 seed stitches on each edge

☐ Seed border: 7 rows at the top

☐ Bound off loosely

☐ Ends woven in and washed

Baby safety

Keep the blanket away from the sleep area of an infant and follow current safe-sleep guidance. It is best for stroller rides, play mats, and cuddling with a grown-up nearby. Wash the finished blanket before use.

Troubleshooting Table

PROBLEM	LIKELY CAUSE	FIX
Edges are wavy	Uneven tension at turns	Pull the first stitch of each row snug; block gently
Stitch count grows	Accidental yarn overs or knitting into the bar	Count each row; tink back to the first extra stitch
Stitch count shrinks	Skipped stitch or unintentional k2tog	Find the gap; pick up the dropped loop with a crochet hook
Holes in the fabric	Yarn forward between stitches	Move yarn between the needle tips; fix by weaving the tail
Fabric is stiff	Needles too small or tension too tight	Try a needle one or two sizes larger
Fabric is floppy	Needles too large	Try a needle one size smaller
Tight cast-on edge	Pulled cast-on stitches too snug	Cast on over two needles held together
Stockinette curls	Natural tendency of the fabric	Add a garter, seed, or rib border; block flat
Rib doesn't pull in	Needle too large or tension loose	Use a needle one or two sizes smaller for the ribbing
Hat is too loose	Gauge looser than pattern	Go down one needle size and recalculate the stitches
Hat is too tight	Gauge tighter than pattern	Go up one needle size or add 4 stitches (keep multiples)
Yarn splits	Needle tip catches the plies	Use blunter needles and go slower

PROBLEM	LIKELY CAUSE	FIX
Hands or wrists ache	Gripping too tightly	Take breaks every 20 minutes and shake out your hands

> **When you are stuck**
>
> Take a photo of your work, put it down, and come back tomorrow. Most problems that look huge are tiny when you see them with fresh eyes.

Your 14-Day Practice Plan

Fifteen to thirty minutes a day is enough. Short, frequent sessions teach your hands faster than one long weekend. Tick off each day as you complete it.

DAY	FOCUS	GOAL
1	Gather supplies, hold needles and yarn, make slip knots	Make 5 slip knots without help
2	Long-tail cast-on	Cast on 20 stitches three times
3	Knit stitch	Knit 10 rows of 20 stitches
4	Knit stitch and counting	Knit 20 rows, count stitches and ridges after each 5 rows
5	Bind off	Bind off your practice piece; cast on and bind off again
6	Dishcloth, part 1	Cast on 40 stitches and knit 40 rows
7	Dishcloth, part 2	Knit rows 41 to 80, bind off, weave in ends
8	Purl stitch	Practice 6 rows of purl, then alternate knit and purl for stockinette
9	Stockinette, fixing mistakes	Drop a stitch on purpose and pick it up with a crochet hook
10	Rib	Cast on 22 stitches and work 30 rows of k2, p2 rib
11	Increases and decreases	Practice kfb, M1, k2tog, and ssk on a swatch
12	Gauge swatch and pattern reading	Knit a swatch and read the hat pattern aloud
13	Start the scarf or headband	Knit 100 rows of the scarf, or 60 rows of the headband
14	Finishing	Weave in ends, block a piece, and plan your next project

PRACTICE PLAN CHECKLIST

☐ Days 1 to 5 complete: slip knot, cast on, knit, bind off

☐ Days 6 and 7 complete: first dishcloth finished

☐ Days 8 to 10 complete: purl, stockinette, rib

☐ Days 11 and 12 complete: shaping and gauge

☐ Days 13 and 14 complete: first real project underway

> **Cheat days are allowed**
>
> If you miss a day, do not start over. Pick up where you left off and take the next day as planned.

If you also like the look of a project you saw in the main collection, choose one with a stitch pattern you now recognize. Check the abbreviations, then swatch before you cast on. If you plan to sell what you make, check the rules of the market or craft fair where you sell.

Next step

Pick up your needles right now. Make a slip knot, cast on 20 stitches, and knit one row. That single row is the hardest step in this whole guide, and you will have done it. Tomorrow, add another ten. In two weeks you will have a dishcloth, a scarf started, and the confidence to open the pattern collection and choose your next project.

YOUR NEXT STEP

☐ Choose your first yarn and needles from the tools chapter

☐ Make a slip knot and cast on 20 stitches today

☐ Knit 10 rows and count your stitches

☐ Start the 14-day plan on Day 1

☐ Pick the pattern you most want to make next, and swatch for it